

**Who am I to (dis)agree?
Interpretation Sensitive Agreement:
Experimental evidence from French relatives***

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Abstract Agreement morphology is often assumed to realize ϕ -features uninterpreted at LF. We provide experimental evidence from French relative clauses showing that agreement can in fact have an interpretative effect, adding to the range of ‘semantic agreement’ effects (e.g. Charnavel & Sportiche 2025). The choice of variable person agreement turns out to be sensitive to the placement of focus. We provide an analysis that relies on the interaction between focus, binding and the distribution of focus-sensitive operators.

Keywords: agreement, focus, copular sentences, relative clauses, superlative, French

1 Introduction

French shows variability in person agreement in ‘Partee sentences’.¹ For example, in (1), both first-person (1P) (tracking the matrix subject *je*) and third-person (3P) agreement (tracking the relative head *le seul* ‘the only one’) are available.

- (1) Je suis le seul qui {suis / est } magicien.
I am the only who be.1SG / 3SG magician
‘I am the only one who {am / is} a magician.’

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¹ Sentences like (1) including bound indexicals from Partee (1989) have been dubbed Partee sentences in Bassi (2021).

(2) a. [Je]_F suis le seul qui {suis / #?est} magicien.
I am the only who be.1SG / 3SG magician
'I_F am the only one who {am / #?is} a magician.'

b. Je suis [le seul qui {#?suis / est } magicien]_F.
I am the only who be.1SG / 3SG magician
'I am [the only one who {#?am / is} a magician]_F.'

(3) Je suis *le *(plus) jeune* qui suis magicien. I am the most young who am magician +Superlative: 1P ✓
'I am the youngest one who is a magician.' –Superlative: 1P ✗

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2 Constraints on variable agreement

In this section, we clarify the restrictions on local person agreement in Partee sentences (namely agreement in the relative clause), focusing on the properties of head, the wider syntactic context in which the relative is embedded, and the placement of focus.²

The type of relative head. First, we newly observe that local person (e.g., 1P/2P) agreement is not available within relative clauses including a full noun as head.

- (4) Je suis le seul *lutin* qui {*suis / est} magicien.
I am the only elf who {be.1SG / be.3SG} magician
'I am the only elf who {*am/is} a magician.'

We additionally observe in (5) that local person agreement is typically licensed in sentences involving adjectival *only* (French *seul*), ordinals like *first* or superlatives without any overt head (cf. Bassi 2019, 2021). Heads that do not include a full noun, but involve a regular (i.e., non-superlative) adjective like *jeune* in (5), do not permit variable agreement. We henceforth subsume these cases within the class of light superlatives (see Charnavel 2025 for discussion).³

- (5) Je suis le {seul / premier / *(plus) jeune} qui {suis / est} magicien.
I am the {only / first / *(most) young} who am / is magician
'I am the only one (first /youngest) who is a magician.'

Copular sentences. Local person agreement only occurs in superlative relative clauses if they are embedded within certain kinds of copular construction.

- (6) J'ai invité (à mon anniversaire) le seul qui {*suis / est} magicien.
I have invited (to my birthday) the only who am / is magician
'I invited (to my birthday) the only one who is a magician.'

Furthermore, only some types of copular sentences are compatible with local person agreement. Canonical specificational sentences like (7) are not.

- (7) Le seul qui {*suis / est} magicien, c'est moi.
the only who am / is magician it.is me
'The only one who is a magician is me.' Inverted Copular Sentence

² Keep in mind that non-restrictive relatives with pronominal heads and cleft-RCs both also show local person agreement. They do not, however, show the same conditioned variation as Partee sentences.

³ Some light heads can nevertheless be found to license local person agreement in the absence of superlative adjectives (cf. Bassi 2019 on Hebrew). These include: *celui* 'the one', *quelqu'un* 'someone' and *l'un des rares* 'one of the few'.

Focus placement. Local person agreement additionally seems to require the matrix subject, rather than the predicate, to be focused (cf. Bassi 2019 on Hebrew). Based on the hypothesis that question-answer congruence induces a correspondence between the *wh*-expression in the question and the focused constituent in the answer, we can use appropriate questions under discussion to locate the foci, as in (8).

- (8) a. A: Quelle est ta spécificité, à toi?
 what is your specificity to you
 ‘What is your specificity?’
 B: Je suis [le seul qui {?suis / est} magicien]_F.
 I am the only who am / is magician
 ‘I am the only one who is a magician.’
 b. A: Qui est le seul magicien ici?
 who is the only magician here
 ‘Who is the only magician here?’
 B: [Je]_F suis le seul qui {suis / ?est} magicien.
 I am the only who am / is magician
 I am the only one who is a magician.’

This generalization is further supported by the observation that clefted (thus focused) copular subjects in (9) can trigger local person agreement, but clitic (thus unfocusable) copular subjects in (10) cannot.

- (9) C’est moi qui {suis / ?est} magicien.
 it.is me who am / is magician
 ‘It is me who is a magician.’
 (10) On *me* considère comme le seul qui {*suis / est} magicien.
 one me considers like the only who am / is magician
 ‘I am considered as the only one who is a magician.’

In the next section, we experimentally test this last generalization.

3 Experimental Study

In this section, we detail our experimental study about the relation between focus placement and agreement variation in French *Partee* sentences. We will henceforth call sentences like (2a) (with focus on the subject) *specificational* sentences [Spec] (which specify the value of an entity), and sentences like (2b) (with focus on the predicate) *predicational* sentences [Pred] (which attribute a property) (see Higgins 1979, Heycock 2020, i.a.).

3.1 Methods

The experiment was run online. The task was a forced-choice task. Participants were presented with dialogue scenarios between a Grey Elf, responsible of the NCS (the National Committee of Superheroes)⁴ and various characters, Jo/Sam/Kim. Participants were asked to complete a sentence with a blank, by choosing one of two agreement options: 1P (e.g. *suis*) or 3P (e.g. *est*), in different contexts manipulating focus placement. Each scenario consisted of (i) a context followed by a question asked by the Grey Elf, and (ii) the answer given by Jo/Sam/Kim, which contained a blanked-out word. Participants were asked to fill in the blank in the answer according to what sounded the most natural to them based on the Grey Elf’s question.

Test sentences were of the form “*Je suis le seul qui {suis/est} capable de Q*” (‘*I am the only one who {am/is} able to Q*’) (*je*-experiment) or “*Nous sommes les seuls qui {soyons/soient} capables de Q*” (‘*We are the only ones who {are-1P/are-3P} able to Q*’) (*nous*-experiment). They could appear in two contexts (QUD). In Pred contexts, the Grey Elf’s question was “What’s your special power?”, thus focus falls on the predicate (see 8a). In Spec contexts, the Grey Elf’s question was “Who is the only one here able to Q?”, thus focus falls on the subject (see 8b). We predict 1P to be available in Spec context and not in Pred context. To ensure participants carefully read the entire dialogue context (crucial for the Context/QUD manipulation), we added a memory question after each dialogue asking to recall the Grey Elf’s question, to underscore that it was crucial to consider the Grey Elf’s precise question. A sample trial is provided in the [supplemental material](#).

Table 1 summarizes conditions and expectations.

	Pred Context	Spec Context
Context	Jo/Sam/Kim is interviewing for a job at the highly selective NSHC.	The NSHC needs a Hero for a Special Mission.
Question	What’s your Special Power?	Who is the only one here able to Q?
Answer [focus]	I am [the only one who am/is able to Q] _F	[I] _F am the only one who am/is able to Q
Expectation	*1P	✓ 1P

Table 1 Summary of Context/QUD manipulation and expectations.

⁴ The NCS (National Committee of Superheroes) is a highly secretive committee that recruits Super Heroes with special abilities, sometimes a little surprising, but always essential to the world’s survival.

Fillers. For fillers (as many as test items), participants had to pick between past and future tense (e.g., “{Je vais dire/J’ai dit} que je sais Q” ‘I said/I’ll say that Q’). Fillers further allowed us to ensure participants carefully read the context and question, since we made sure the correct answer could not be guessed based on the target sentence alone. Like test cases, fillers were balanced for focus placement (whether Q is included in Grey Elf’s question, or new in the answer). They were also balanced for person subjects (1P: “I said/I’ll say that” vs 3P: “Sam said/Sam will say that”). There were thus 8 kinds of fillers, crossing Tense (past vs future), whether Q is given/new, and whether the subject in the answer is 1st or 3rd person. We used the same list of superpowers across fillers and test cases.

Material. We created a list consisting of 48 different superpowers (“eat oranges with the skin on”, “turn water into acid”, “find the north without a compass”, etc). All superpowers took the form Verb-inf + NP-comp + PP-comp/adverbial. We never used the same verb/NP/PP-comp twice. The superpowers’ naturalness was checked in a prior experiment, where we asked (n=10) French native speakers to evaluate an initial list of 60 superpowers on naturalness (do you find the wording of this special ability strange or natural? strange/natural). The final list (48/60) of superpowers we selected was based on naturalness rating’s highest ranking.

To try and limit prescriptivism, we added explicit instructions at the beginning and used in the training (with feedback) some examples prescriptively wrong (e.g. with *pas* without overt negator *ne*).

Conditions. We ran two versions of the experiment.⁵ The first one involved singular 1P agreement in the indicative (*suis* ‘am’ vs. *est* ‘is’) (see 11), the second one involved plural 1P agreement in the subjunctive (*soyons* ‘were-1P’ vs. *soient* ‘were-3P’) as the singular involves no audible difference between 1P *sois* and 3P *soit* (see 12). This allowed us to control for syncretism and indicative/subjunctive variable speaker preference. Context/QUD (Pred vs Spec) was tested within subject, Number (*je* vs *nous*) between subject.

- (11) Je suis le seul qui {suis / est } capable de Q.
 I am the only who be.1SG / be.3SG able to Q
 ‘I am the only one who {am / is} able to Q.’

⁵ We first ran the *je*-experiment. A reason why we ran the *nous*-experiment is that in the comments, a number of participants indicated that they disliked both *est* and *suis*, and would rather use the subjunctive (*sois/soit*), the problem being that the difference between indicative and subjunctive is not audible with singular 1P; however, it is in the plural (e.g., *soyons* ‘be.SUBJ.1P’ vs. *soient* ‘be.SUBJ.3P’). Note that a few participants in the *nous*-experiment then mentioned they would – conversely – rather use the indicative than the subjunctive (*sommes/sont*).

- (12) Nous sommes les seuls qui {soyons / soient} capables de Q.
 We are the only-pl who be.1PL.SN / be.3PL.SN able to Q
 ‘We are the only ones who {are / are} able to Q.’

Procedure Experiments were coded using PennController for Ibex (pcibex.net) and run online on PCIBex Farm (Zehr & Schwarz 2018). Participants first saw instructions, then 4 training items with feedback. In the test phase, each participant had 48 dialogue contexts to judge: 24 test cases (12 Spec, 12 Pred); 24 fillers (12 past, 12 future, half P1, half P3, half P-new, half P-given). Dialogues were presented in randomized order. Participants never saw the same superpower twice. To display each dialogue, participants had to press the space button, making each part of the context appear incrementally. Each trial was followed by a memory question, on a separate screen, asking to recall the question asked by the Grey Elf, by picking between three options. The average duration of the experiment was 12 minutes. At the end, participants were asked if they had any comments about the task. Demonstrations are available at [je-experiment](#) and [nous-experiment](#). Instructions, training items and summary of the procedure are available in the [supplemental material](#).

3.2 Participants

161 French native speakers were recruited via Prolific (prolific.com) (80 participants per version of the experiment, counterbalanced across four groups (*je*-experiment: 34F, 45M, 1 other; mean age 37.7; age range: 19 to 75yrs; *nous*-experiment: 43F, 37M, 1 other; mean age: 35.3; age range: 20 to 64yrs). Participants were paid 2€ for their participation. Exclusion criteria were native language (French) and age (over 18-year-old). We excluded 12 participants because of low accuracy scores on attention checks and fillers (7.5%). We thus report results for 149 participants (*je*-experiment: 77; *nous*-experiment: 72).

3.3 Analysis and results

Data analyses were conducted using R (R Core Team 2013), using the package lme4 (Bates, Mächler & Bolker 2014; Bates, Mächler, Bolker & Walker 2015). To analyse participants’ responses, we used a generalized linear mixed-effects model (GLMM) built with a maximal random effect structure allowed by our experimental design (following Barr, Levy, Scheepers & Tily 2013), implemented with the lme4 package (Bates et al. 2015), testing Answer (dependent variable, binomial), with Context as fixed effect and Subject by Context and Item by Context as random intercepts,

comparing them with a model without Context as a fixed effect (glmer syntax of the full model: $\text{Answer}==1 \sim \text{Context} + (\text{Context} \mid \text{Subject}) + (\text{Context} \mid \text{Item})$; reduced model: $\text{Answer}==1 \sim 1 + (\text{Context} \mid \text{Subject}) + (\text{Context} \mid \text{Item})$). Answer was coded as 1 when participants answered 1P (e.g. *suis*) and 0 when they answered 3P (e.g. *est*).

Accuracy on attention checks (memory questions) was high (*je*-experiment: 97.2%; *nous*-experiment: 95.0%), with no participant to exclude. Accuracy on past/future fillers was also high (*je*-experiment: 95.6%; *nous*-experiment: 91.7%) (12 participants to exclude) (final number of participants: *je*-experiment: 77; *nous*-experiment: 72).

Results of the model testing the effect of Context show that overall, participants tend to pick 1P more often in Spec contexts than in Pred contexts (*je*-experiment: Spec: 36.6% of 1P answers vs Pred: 33.8% of 1P answers; *nous*-experiment: 44.2% vs. 41.8%). The difference was significant overall, $\chi^2(1) = 4.10$, $p = .042^*$; $b = -0.38$, $SE = 0.17$, $z = -2.25$, $p = .024^*$, but not within the subexperiments (*je*-experiment, $\chi^2(1) = 1.25$, $p = .26$; $b = 0.47$, $SE = 0.42$, $z = 1.12$, $p = .26$; *nous*-experiment, $\chi^2(1) = 1.79$, $p = .18$; $b = -0.28$, $SE = 0.19$, $z = -1.40$, $p = .160$).

Post-hoc analyses suggest that the effect is partially washed out by repetition. Indeed, just comparing the very first judgment reveals a larger difference (overall: Pred: 32% vs Spec: 43%; *je*-experiment: Pred: 22% vs Spec: 32%; *nous*-experiment: Pred: 42% vs Spec: 54%) (the difference is not significant because we only have 1 observation per participant). We also see a priming effect of person’s fillers: when the previous filler involved 1P answers (e.g. picking between “I said/I will say”), participants tend to answer 1P on the subsequent trial, whereas when fillers involved 3P answers (e.g. “Sam said/Sam will say”), participants tend to answer 3P. Results are summarized in Table 2.

	Expect: 1P ok?	SG+IND	PL+SUBJ	SG+IND / PL+SUBJ (1st judgment)
Pred	X	33.8%	41.8%	22% / 42%
Spec	✓	36.6%	44.2%	32% / 54%

Table 2 Proportion of 1P (vs. 3P) answers

Results by participants Figure 1 plots results by participants, with proportion of 1P answers in Pred (X-axis) vs Spec (Y-axis). Across the two experiments, 41 participants always answer 3P (bottom left corners); 14 always answer 1P (upright corners) (in *je*-experiment (left plot), 27 participants always answer 3P and 6 participants always answer 1P; in *nous*-experiment (right plot), 14 participants always answer 3P and 8 participants always answer 1P).

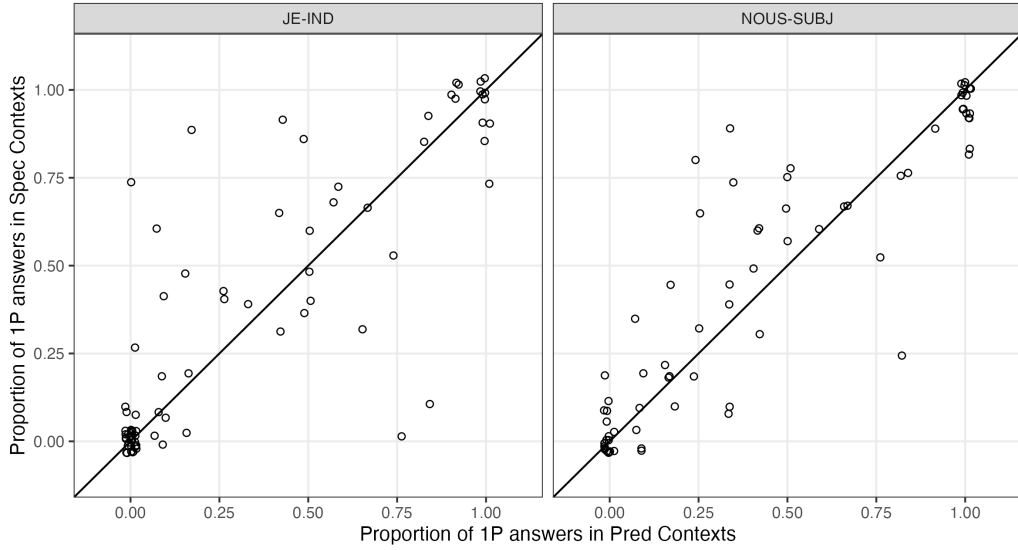


Figure 1 Results by participant. Each dot represents one participant. A jitter was added to make results readable. There are 24 test cases per participant, 12 Pred and 12 Spec.

4 Analysis

The nature of agreement: We assume, following [Charnavel & Sportiche \(2025\)](#), that phi-features on T can in certain circumstances be interpreted at LF. This happens only when these features fail to find an appropriate nominal to match in person/number with. Such a failure arises in relative clauses, if we assume (with [Charnavel et al 2025](#)) that in French the relative trace (in Spec, TP) is underspecified for person but not for number.⁶

When phi-features on T have ‘semantic import’, they encode a presupposition. Just like how the 1P feature on a pronoun like *I* constrains the domain of its individual variable argument (under the assumption that the individual-denoting variable is an argument of the Person head; see [Heim 2008](#) i.a.), we hypothesize that T endowed with 1P features can induce a presupposition on its specifier at LF, namely, that its referent must include the speaker *s* of the utterance context *c*.

$$(13) \quad \llbracket 1st \rrbracket^{c,g} = \lambda x: x \text{ includes } s_c. x$$

⁶ To our knowledge, relative pronouns never show inflection in person (cf. e.g., [den Dikken 2019](#)). This is compatible with them being negatively specified for person, or merely underspecified. We hypothesize that relative pronouns vary crosslinguistically on this point. A similar variability may also hold of light or null nominals.

Recall that 1P agreement is incompatible with overt/full lexical heads like *le seul lutin* ('the only elf'). We hypothesize that light heads such *le seul* or *celui* ('the (only) one') are, like relative pronouns, underspecified in person. This makes them compatible with 1P presupposition supplied by T. By contrast, full heads are specified 3P, and thus contradict the presupposition induced by 1P agreement.

As detailed in Charnavel & Sportiche (2025), such 'semantic agreement' is independently attested in French and elsewhere, and is exemplified in (14). Here there is another choice of agreement that correlates with a difference in interpretation. While the 1P plural agreement *sommes* induces an interpretation under which the speaker herself must be on holidays, the 3P agreement does not and is compatible with a situation where most members of the speaker's group are on holidays.

- (14) Une majorité d'entre nous {est / sommes / sont} en vacances.
 a majority of/among us be.3SG / 1PL / 3PL on vacation
 'A majority of us {is/are/are} on vacation.'

The details of how semantic agreement functions, its scope and the division of labor with syntactic agreement here is discussed in Charnavel & Sportiche (2025). Here, it is sufficient to hypothesize that semantic agreement is sometimes available when syntactic agreement fails, thus yielding agreement variability with semantic import. The semantic import is clear in (14), as just discussed. It is less so in (1), but becomes apparent in the presence of an indexical:

- (15) Je suis le seul qui {suis / #est} capable de retrouver mon chemin.
 I am the only who be.1SG / be.3SG able to find my way
 'I am the only one who is able to find my way.'

As detailed in Charnavel & Sportiche (2024) or Charnavel, Meadows & Sportiche (2024), 1P agreement in examples like (15) licenses a sloppy reading (i.e., the others are not able to find their way). The hypothesis that the sloppy reading is licensed by 1P agreement is further supported by the observation that the sloppy reading is hardly available in constructions where 1P agreement is absent (see further discussion on this 'Subject Restriction' in Charnavel et al. (2024)).

- (16) Je suis le seul que Luc trouve capable de retrouver {#mon / son} chemin.
 I am the only who Luc finds able to find my / his way
 'I am the only one who Luc considers able to find my way.'

To summarise, the first step of our account is allowing for the very possibility of phi-features on T being interpreted at LF. This is tied to the existence of nominals underspecified for person. What still needs to be accounted for is why agreement in Partee sentences being interpreted at LF should require focus on the matrix subject.

Binding by focused pronoun: To better understand the role of focus here, let's compare (1) (repeated as (17)) with a simpler version without relative clause in (18). In both cases, *seul* induces and negates alternatives (i.e., the others are not magicians).

- (17) Je suis le seul qui suis magicien. (18) Seul moi suis magicien.
 I am the only who am magician only me am magician
 'I am the only one who is a magician.' 'Only I am a magician.'

More precisely, we can assume as in Rooth (1992) that *seul*, like *only* in (19), is a focus propositional operator quantifying over focus alternatives C (for a review and discussion of alternative analyses, see Hirsch 2017, i.a.).

$$(19) \quad \llbracket \text{only/seul} \rrbracket = \lambda C. \lambda p: p = 1. \forall q \in C [q \neq p \rightarrow q = 0]$$

In (18), *only* thus presupposes the prejacent in (20a) and quantifies over (and negates) the focus alternatives in (20b).

- (20) a. $\llbracket \text{I am a magician} \rrbracket^O = s_c$ is a magician
 b. $\llbracket p \rrbracket^f = \llbracket I_F \text{ am a magician} \rrbracket^f = \{x \text{ is a magician} \mid x \in D_e\}$

Crucially, the set of alternatives to the prejacent p in (20b) (i.e., the focus meaning of p noted $\llbracket p \rrbracket^f$ under Rooth's alternative semantics) involves individuals x , because the focus meaning of an F-marked individual is assumed to be a set of individuals that is unrestricted (except by the pragmatics of the discourse); in effect, the person presupposition of *moi* (I_F) is thus not interpreted in the focus alternatives.

Now, we presumably want to obtain the same effect in (17), where non-magicians are also understood to be non-speakers. But given its adjectival position and the absence of focus prosody, it is not obvious that *seul* in (17) takes a proposition as argument and associates with focus in the same way as *seul* in (18).⁷

To solve this problem, recall first that such relative clauses with 1P agreement are simply ill formed outside of particular copular sentences, unlike their 3P agreement counterparts as discussed in section 2: relative clause external copular structure plays a crucial role in licensing 1P agreement inside the relative clause. To explain this role and the focus requirement on the subject of the copular structure, we adopt the principle underlying Charnavel & Sportiche's 2024 analysis of indexical binding, spelled out below. Now consider the binding configuration in (21), paralleling that of (22):

⁷ We will nevertheless adopt the hypothesis that adjectival *only* quantifies over focus alternatives, pace McNally 2008; Sharvit 2015, i.a.), see Jacobson (2012) and further discussion in the section on the role of adjectival *only*. Under the alternative hypothesis that it quantifies over a domain not determined by focus, we would have to explain why the presupposition does not universally project as is usually the case with universal quantifiers (see discussion in Chemla 2009, i.a.).

(21) [Je]_F suis le seul qui t suis magicien


‘I am the only one who is a magician.’

(22) Seul [moi]_F est fier de moi


‘Only I am proud of myself.’

Standardly, binding requires a match (or a lack of mismatch to be precisely characterized) in presuppositions between binder and bindee. Charnavel & Sportiche (2024) propose that when binders and bindees have identical presuppositions, they unify: the presupposition of a variable is encoded only once and simultaneously restrict the range of all occurrences of this variable. This entails that when the binder is focused, the presupposition is ignored in focus alternatives for all occurrences of the variable (i.e., in (22), $\{x \text{ is proud of } x \mid x \in D_e\}$). Here the focused 1P element binds another element interpreted as 1P, the presupposition of both binder and bindee disappears in the focus alternatives. This gives rise to the sloppy reading in (22) (i.e., noone else is proud of themselves).

The same can hold in (21): *je_F* can similarly bind the relative trace (possibly via binding of the head of the relative), thus canceling the 1P presupposition in the focus alternatives and triggering the interpretation that the others (not speakers) are not magicians.⁸ This hypothesis derives several of the constraints on variable agreement in Partee sentences that we have observed in section 2.

First, the presupposition induced by semantic 1P agreement in the relative clause should not be interpreted in the alternatives: since alternatives reference people other than the speaker,⁹ semantic 1P agreement would yield a presupposition failure. That this presupposition disappears under binding by a focused element is a consequence of our proposal.

Second, in conjunction with the discussion below around example (43), it derives why 1P agreement is unavailable in inverted copular sentences like (23) (= (7)).

(23) Le seul qui t { *suis / est } magicien, c’est moi.
 the only who t am / is magician it.is me
 ‘The only one who {am/is} a magician, it’s me.’

Here, focused *moi* is not in the relevant structural position to bind the relative trace¹⁰ so the 1P presupposition cannot be canceled this way.

⁸ In (22), the strict reading (i.e., the others are not proud of me) obtains in the absence of binding of the embedded *moi*. In (21), the strict reading is ill formed as 1P agreement is incompatible with non speaker alternatives induced by the focus on *je_F*.

⁹ We assume that pragmatically restricting the set of alternative individuals to the speaker only is disallowed: *only* requires its quantification domain to not be a singleton.

¹⁰ This is independently shown by the following examples: the sentence *Seulement Pierre est le soutien*

Third, our hypothesis can derive why only copular sentences can license local person agreement as shown in (6) repeated below.

- (24) J'ai invité (à mon anniversaire) le seul qui { *suis / est } magicien.
 I.have invited (to my birthday) the only who am / is magician
 'I invited (to my birthday) the only one who is a magician.'

That the 1P feature on T is interpreted as a presupposition in the relative means that the subject trace, hence the whole relative clause must end up denoting the speaker of the utterance, else ill formedness ensues. This triggers a Condition C violation. The contrast between (24) (=6) and (1) thus reduces to that between (25) and (26).

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(25) *J_i' ai invité Isabelle_i.
 I have invited Isabelle
 '*I invited Isabelle.'</p> | <p>(26) Je_i suis Isabelle_i.
 I am Isabelle
 'I am Isabelle.'</p> |
|--|--|

This contrast is independently known to hold: Condition C is not violated in copular sentences (because they assert covaluation instead of presupposing it).

Fourth, our hypothesis accounts for our core observation, that is, for why the matrix pronoun must be focused for local person agreement to obtain in the relative clause as shown in (8a), (8b) and (10). In (10), due to the absence of focus on *me*, the 1P presupposition induced by semantic agreement must be interpreted in the (non trivial - see footnote 9) focus alternatives, thus yielding a contradiction (as such sentences would both imply that the speaker is a magician (due to the prejacent) and that the speaker is not a magician (due to the alternatives)) In sum, the interaction between agreement and focus results from the presuppositionality of agreement and the focus blindness to presuppositions. Agreement optionality is available in focus constructions because focus induces two levels of interpretations, one in which presuppositions are interpreted, and the other one where they are not.

The role of adjectival *only*: Under the analysis proposed, focus on the matrix pronoun is thus required for semantic agreement to obtain because the 1P presupposition it induces should not be interpreted in the focus alternatives. Given the resemblance between (17) and (18), this suggests that adjectival *only* quantifies over focus alternatives. This section clarifies how this is possible.

de ses parents/only Peter is the support of his parents allows a sloppy reading (nobody else is the support of his parents) which requires *Pierre/Peter* to bind *ses/his*; but *le soutien de ses parents, c'est seulement Pierre/ lit. the support of his parents it's only Peter* does not, showing that *Pierre/Peter* cannot bind *ses/his* in the inverted copular structure.

We saw in Section 2 that local person agreement is usually licensed in sentences involving superlatives, i.e., extreme ordinals or canonical superlatives, in addition to adjectival *only*. A natural account for this observation about superlatives relies on their focus sensitivity as they are usually assumed to be focus sensitive under their relative reading illustrated in (27b) (Szabolcsi 1986; Heim 1995/1999 i.a.).

- (27) a. John climbed the highest mountain. (i.e., Mt Everest) [*absolute reading*]
b. John_F climbed the highest mountain. (i.e., a higher mountain than everybody else did) [*relative reading*]

Under the absolute reading in (27a), the mountain John climbed is the highest of all mountains (i.e., Mount Everest). Under the relative reading, it only needs to be higher than the mountains climbed by the other relevant climbers. Crucially, this reading is favored by focusing *John*, which motivates analyses deriving relative readings from focus association of the superlative morpheme *-est*. Under the analysis in Heim (1995/1999) exemplified in (28), such focus association obtains through movement of *-est* above the focused constituent, and *-est* is hypothesized to be a propositional degree operator quantifying over focus alternatives C as in (29).¹¹

- (28) C -est [John_F climbed (the) d-high mountain]
C = { $\lambda d. x$ climbed a d-high mountain}
(29) $\llbracket \text{-est} \rrbracket (C)(P) = 1$ iff $\exists d \mid P(d)=1$ and $\forall Q \in C$ and $Q \subseteq P, Q(d)=0$

The main arguments for assuming *-est* movement to derive relative readings are so-called upstairs *de dicto* readings involving intensional operators like *want* as in (30), and island effects as in (31) (see details in Heim 1995/1999, i.a.).

- (30) a. John wants to climb the highest mountain.
b. C-est [John_F wants to climb (the) d-high mountain] *est* > *want* > *d-high*
(31) a. #John admires everyone who climbed the highest mountain.
b. *C -est [John_F admires everyone who climbed (the) d-high mountain.]

The relevant reading in (30) arises in scenarios where John and other individuals each have a specific (but non-comparative) athletic ambition (e.g., John wants to climb a 4000 m high mountain, Mary a 3000m high one, and Bill a 2000m high one), and the speaker makes a comparison between these desires. As argued by Heim

¹¹ Heim (1995/1999) proposes two focus-based analyses, one under which *-est* is individual-based (i.e., *-est* takes a relation between degrees and individuals, an individual and C – a set of individuals) and another one under which it is proposition-based (*-est* takes a property of degrees and C – a set of degree properties). We here adopt the latter analysis.

(1995/1999), this can only be captured by splitting the scope of *-est* and *d-high* with respect to the intensional operator *want*. In (31), the point is that the unavailability of the relative reading (i.e., other people than John admire people who climbed lower mountains) directly derives from a movement analysis, as *-est* cannot move out of the relative clause due to island constraints.

Given this analysis of superlatives, we expect two possible LFs for a sentence like *I am the tallest who is here* (yielding the same truth values in these copular sentences):

(32) *-est* [I_F am [(the) d-tall who is here]] yielding the relative reading

(33) I am the [*-est* [d- tall who is here]] yielding the absolute reading

Now, crucially, Sharvit (2015) observes that adjectival *only* also exhibits relative readings, island effects and upstairs *de dicto* readings as shown in (34)–(36).

(34) Anna didn't give the only good talk.
can mean: Other people gave a good talk.

(35) #Anna didn't cry after giving the only good talk.
cannot mean: Other people cried after giving a good talk.

(36) Mary recommended the only book. *only* > *recommend* > *book*
can mean: Other people did not recommend a book.

How to analyze adjectival *only* is debated. But given these striking similarities between adjectival *only* and superlatives,¹² as well as that between *-est* in (29) and adverbial *only* in (19), we hypothesize that adjectival *only*, just like *-est* or adverbial *only*, is a propositional focus sensitive operator that can covertly move above the constituent it associates with (cf. Sharvit 2015) removing a problematic lexical ambiguity between adverbial and adjectival *only*.¹³

Applied to *seul*, this means first that *seul* can, as shown in (37), associate with *je* in (17), thus directly accounting for the similarity to (18) (i.e., *Only I am a magician*).

(37) Seul [J_e suis (le) ~~seul~~ qui suis magicien]
Only I am (the) ~~only~~ who am magician
'I am the only one who is a magician.'

Under this analysis, 1P agreement in the relative 37 (=17)) is ultimately licensed via focus association of *seul* (*only*) with *je* (*I*), which cancels the 1P presupposition in focus alternatives due to binding of the relative trace by *je*.

12 There are further similarities, such as the non-definiteness of the definite article (see Sharvit 2015; Bumford 2017, i.a.), the licensing of non-modal subject infinitival clauses and that of NPIs (see Bhatt 2006, i.a.), as well as that of indexical binding (see Bassi 2021, i.a.).

13 A full specification of the analysis (beyond the scope of this article) would require detailing the type of scales involved for superlatives, adjectival *only* and adverbial *only* (e.g., degrees for superlatives, cardinalities for adjectival *only*, objective or subjective scales for (scalar) adverbial *only*).

Now in some cases, *seul/premier* (*only/first*) cannot move and associate with some external DP, e.g. with *moi* in (38) (= (7)) due to the structural configuration, or with *me* in (39) (= (10)) due to the clitic's unfocusability.

- (38) Le seul/premier qui { *suis / est } magicien, c'est moi.
 the only/first who be.1SG / be.3SG magician, it's me
 'The only/first one who { *am/is } a magician, it's me.'
- (39) On me croit le seul/premier qui { *suis / est } magicien.
 one me believes the only/first who be.1SG / be.3SG magician
 'They believe me to be the only/first one who { *am/is } a magician.'

This is expected given the existence of absolute readings LFs as in (33). But how should they be analyzed? We adopt the null hypothesis endorsing a uniform, focus-based analysis of absolute and relative readings of superlatives.¹⁴ What then does adjectival *only* or superlative *first* focus-associate with in such cases (corresponding to what happens with the absolute reading of superlatives)? We sketch below an extension to *seul / only* in (41) of the focus analysis of absolute readings shown in (40) (see Romero 2011, i.a.) according to which *only* associates with a silent NP-internal element, like the superlative morpheme *-est* does under an absolute reading:

- (40) a. He climbed the *-est* [_{pro_F} d-high mountain] Romero (2011)
 b. $C = \{ \lambda d \mid x \text{ is a } d\text{-high mountain} \}$
- (41) a. le seul _{pro_F} qui { est / *suis } magicien.
 the only _{pro} who is / am magician
 'The only one who is a magician.'
 b. $C = \{ \lambda d \mid d \text{ number of } x \text{ who is a magician} \}$

Such an analysis immediately accounts for Jacobson's 2012 observation that sloppy readings are available in sentences such as:

- (42) a. La seule qui parle d'elle, c'est Anna.
 the only who talks about her, it's Anna
 'The only one who talks about herself is Anna.'

¹⁴ Although this seems desirable for economy reasons, proposals instead assume diverging analyses (and different lexical entries for *-est*) for relative readings (usually focus-based) and absolute readings (not focus-based). Such not focus-based analyses of absolute *-est* could presumably be extended to adjectival *only* with 3P agreement, but a uniform, focus-based analysis is a priori preferable.

- b. *la seule pro_F^k qui parle d'elle^k*
 the-fem only-fem *pro^k* who talks about *her^k*
 'The only one who talks about herself.'

Here, *pro^k* marked with feminine gender can bind *her^k* also marked feminine. As a result, the presupposition feminine triggers is unified and disappear in the alternatives triggered by focus on *pro*, correctly allowing alternatives to include male individuals (e.g., Bill does not talk about himself, etc ...)

What is left to account for is why this analysis does not allow the cancellation of person presupposition either on T in (43a), which is therefore ill formed, or on bound pronouns in (43b) which precludes a sloppy reading:

- (43) a. **Le seul qui suis malade, c'est moi*
 the only who am sick, it's me
 the only one who is sick is me.
- b. *le seul qui parle de moi, c'est moi*
 the only who talks about me, it's me
 the only one who talks about me is me *non sloppy only*

We are led to assume that while this *pro* can be marked for gender (as reflected in the feminine agreement on *la, seule* in (42a)), it can't be marked for person: it is compatible with a 1P interpretation but cannot carry a 1P presupposition that could lead to the cancellation of the 1P presupposition on T or on *moi/me* in (43a) and (43b). The only way to achieve this cancellation in such cases must be via the 'relative reading' structure in (37) where *seul (only)* raises out.

QUD focus and superlative focus: In our discussion so far, we have only considered the role of lexical properties of superlatives or of *only* in the interaction between focus and agreement. Yet, our experiment crucially manipulated the context (i.e., the QUD) for varying focus placement. How do our experimental results fit with our proposed analysis?

Our analysis does not require the presence of any focus sensitive element for local agreement to obtain: the presence of a focused binder of the relative trace is sufficient and focus can be induced by context, as would arise in cases mentioned in footnote 3, (44) being one example. As long as matrix *je* is focused (e.g., through question-answer congruence), local agreement is predicted to be available.¹⁵

¹⁵ The hypothesis that focus is possible and even required here is supported by the availability of sloppy readings with *celui* and local pronouns (e.g., *je suis celui qui suis parti de chez moi*, i.e., the others did not leave home) and the fact that a DP with *celui* and local agreement cannot appear as subject referring to the speaker (e.g., **Celui qui suis magicien vais ouvrir le spectacle*).

(44) A: Qui est le magicien ici? (Who is the magician here?)

B: Je_F suis celui qui t suis magicien.

I am the.one who t be.1SG magician
'I am the one who is a magician.'

The question raised by our experiment, then, is how focus association with *only* and question-answer congruence interact (cf. Sugarawa 2016). Recall the main contrast we observed in (8) as we analyzed it. In (8b), both question-answer congruence and focus association with *seul (only)* (under movement of *seul (only)*) converge for inducing focus on *je (I)*; local agreement is thus directly predicted under binding of the relative trace by *je (I)*. In (8a) however, question-answer congruence induces focus on the predicate, which conflicts with *seul (only)* focus-associating with *je (I)*. Similarly, *Seul moi suis magicien (only I am a magician)* would be an incongruent answer in (8a) vs. (8b). This explains the significant contrast we obtained between (8a) and (8b).

This said, it is possible in principle to dissociate focus association with *only* and question-answer congruence, which would give rise to different agreement possibilities as represented in (45a).

(45) a. seul [je_F suis [(le) ~~seul~~ qui suis magicien]_F].

only I am (the) only who be.1SG magician
'Only I am the only one who is a magician.'

b. Je_F suis le seul pro_F qui est magicien.

I_F am the only pro_F who be.3SG magician
'I am the only pro who is a magician.'

Such representations are presumably dispreferred due to discourse coherence, but not impossible with some accommodation, which may account for why the contrast obtained in the experiment between (8a) and (8b) remains small.

Remaining issues: Analytically, we have not discussed in detail exactly when the head of the relative clause in (1) is compatible with 1P/2P local agreement, merely noting that some pro-forms are (e.g. *one*, *lui* of *celui*), while (at least some) full nouns, silent nouns (cf. ill-formedness of (3) without *plus*) or *pro* in e.g. (41) are not. An analysis would require engaging the complex question of the structure of the head of the relative and its relation to the relative clause, as well as assessing in more detail the relevant data. This is an issue we are currently investigating, in part experimentally. Empirically, there may be other factors explaining why *suis* is accepted by some speakers in (8a) and *est* is accepted by some speakers in (8b), contrary to expectations: they may include prescriptivism (imposing 1P agreement) and default agreement (imposing 3P agreement), respectively.

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